

SECTION NINE

TECHNOLOGY & INFRASTRUCTURE

Every romantasy is shaped by what's easy and what's hard in its world. Will your characters be able to communicate with one another when separated or will being apart for months result in no communication? Can they steal a private moment, or is someone always watching? Are wounds fatal or just a small price to pay for injury? The technology of your world answers these questions for you and these answers build the emotional structure of your entire romance.

Don't get caught up in specifics at this time. Focus on how technology shapes daily life, what it enables, and what it prevents.

The Constraint Engine Principle

Technology is your story's constraint engine. Every technological decision either adds or removes an obstacle between your characters, and obstacles are what romance feeds off of. But here's the thing that makes technology constraints so powerful: they almost never function solely as obstacles. They also serve as intimacy accelerators. The same dragon bond that forces Violet and Xaden into proximity in *Fourth Wing* is also the reason they spend enough time together to move from suspicion to reluctant trust to something more. The constraint slows down the romance but at the same time fuels it.

Consider it this way. A world where characters can teleport, communicate instantly, heal any wound, and lock doors so no one can get in is a world without distance, longing, danger, and stolen moments. That's a world with very few romantic constraints. Now picture the opposite: a world where it takes weeks to travel, letters can be read by others before they arrive, a fever could kill you and the walls are thin enough to hear someone whispering. This is a world that is creating tension, vulnerability and yearning on every page.

This doesn't mean low-tech is automatically better than high-tech. What it means is that every technology choice has a romantic consequence, and you should be making those choices deliberately. If you provide your characters with instant communication, you've removed the ache of waiting, so you'll need to find another source of tension. If you make healing magic simple, then you cannot use injury as your constraint, so something else will have to be. The constraint engine only stalls when everything is easy. Find something that is difficult.

Technology constraints work through two mechanisms: **containment** and **conversion**. Containment is how your world manufactures unavoidable contact. Inn rooms, sleeping bags, escorted travel, shared dragon flights, carriages where there is no space to move away from each other. Conversion is how physical proximity gets translated into an emotional beat. Injury requiring touch, touch legitimising confession, shared meals revealing class difference, bathing creating vulnerability.

Effective romantasy technology choices do both simultaneously. The snowbound inn in *A Court of Mist and Fury* contains Feyre and Rhysand in the same bed while converting that closeness into confessional

pacing. And the sleeping bag in *From Blood and Ash* contains Poppy and Hawke while converting body heat into erotic tension. Once you get the containment right, the conversion follows.

Your most powerful romantic technology choices will also create asymmetry: one character has some advantage over the other in terms of access to information or resources. She can send messages through enchanted mirrors; he has to wait for a letter that takes three weeks. He lives in a palace with locked doors; she sleeps in a crowded room with four other people. Think of Feyre arriving in Prythian in *A Court of Thorns and Roses*, suddenly immersed in a world of Fae magic, wealth, and technology she's never encountered, unable to read the simplest sign. This disparity between what Tamlin views as normal and what overwhelms Feyre drives their early dynamic. His world is alien, and her disorientation creates both vulnerability and resentment. The disparity between worlds creates friction, dependency, and curiosity; all the raw material romance is built from.

What are the key technology constraints in your world?

The Constraint Engine principle says every technology choice either adds or removes an obstacle between your characters. The most powerful choices do both: they force proximity (containment) while creating emotional intensity (conversion). Map your world's biggest technology constraints and identify what each one does to your romance.

TECHNOLOGY CONSTRAINT	CONTAINMENT (HOW IT FORCES PROXIMITY)	CONVERSION (HOW PROXIMITY BECOMES EMOTIONAL)	ASYMMETRY (DOES ONE CHARACTER HAVE AN ADVANTAGE?)
<i>Dragon bond requires physical proximity (Fourth Wing)</i>	<i>Riders must stay within range of each other's dragons</i>	<i>Forced closeness lets suspicion become reluctant trust</i>	<i>Xaden understands the bond; Violet is learning</i>

How to Think About Technology in Romantasy

Technology affects romance through five key channels. When you're building your world's tech level, think about what each choice creates:

CHANNEL	WHAT IT CONTROLS	LOW-TECH CREATES	HIGH-TECH CREATES
Distance	How hard it is to reach each other	Longing, journey-as-intimacy, painful separation	Pressure of constant access, inability to hide
Communication	How they stay connected apart	Ache of waiting, misunderstandings, treasured letters	Immediacy, nowhere to hide behind distance
Privacy	Where they can be unobserved	Stolen moments, risk of discovery, performance	Isolation, chosen vulnerability, no excuses
Vulnerability	What can hurt or kill them	High stakes, caretaking intimacy, real danger	Different stakes needed, emotional vulnerability
Identity	What can be proven or hidden	Fluid identity, secret marriages, reinvention	Accountability, inescapable pasts

Here's what these patterns look like on the page.

The strongest romantic technology constraints produce what you might call *micro-intimacy with interruption*: touch that must be hidden, words that must be delayed, care that must be given without claiming ownership. The interruption keeps the barrier intact while still feeding the relationship, which is why stolen moments under surveillance land harder than leisurely conversations in safety. If you can only touch for three seconds before someone rounds the corner, those three seconds carry the weight of an entire scene.

TECHNOLOGY CHOICE	ROMANTIC PATTERN	ROMANTASY EXAMPLE
Slow travel	Forced proximity on the road, journey romance	The snowbound inn in <i>ACOMAF</i> , one room, one bed, and nowhere to go. The sleeping bag scene in <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , body heat shared out of necessity
Unreliable communication	Misunderstandings that fester, dramatic irony	In <i>Bridgerton</i> , a pregnancy letter must be physically delivered; in <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , the Maiden's communication ban turns every conversation into transgression
No privacy	Stolen moments carry enormous weight	Jude and Cardan's clandestine kiss in <i>The Cruel Prince</i> , desire that must be immediately re-contained because exposure is dangerous
Limited medicine	Caretaking as intimacy, genuine fear of loss	Hawke giving his blood to heal Poppy in <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , healing that doubles as identity revelation and changes everything
Weak documentation	Secret marriages, hidden identities	A union no one can prove, or disprove
Technology gap between characters	Dependency, wonder, shame, teaching moments	A character who's never seen running water arriving

TECHNOLOGY CHOICE	ROMANTIC PATTERN	ROMANTASY EXAMPLE
		in a palace with enchanted plumbing, culture shock as romantic vulnerability

What does micro-intimacy look like for your characters?

The strongest romantic technology constraints produce touch that must be hidden, words that must be delayed, and care that must be given without claiming ownership. The interruption keeps the barrier intact while feeding the relationship. If your characters can only touch for three seconds before someone rounds the corner, those three seconds carry the weight of an entire scene.

MOMENT	WHAT THE MICRO-INTIMACY LOOKS LIKE	WHAT INTERRUPTS IT	WHAT IT REVEALS ABOUT THE RELATIONSHIP
<i>Jude and Cardan's kiss (The Cruel Prince)</i>	<i>A single kiss, immediately re- contained</i>	<i>Exposure is too dangerous at court</i>	<i>Desire exists but must be suppressed</i>

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question in this section will apply to your world. A futuristic setting won't need to answer questions about candlelight; a pre-industrial world won't deal with mass communication. Skip what doesn't serve your story! But pay attention to the questions that make you uncomfortable or uncertain. Those are often the ones that reveal the most interesting constraints.

Common Mistakes with Technology

Mistake #1: The Convenience Trap

Magic or technology solves every problem. Instant teleportation, perfect healing, unbreakable privacy wards, flawless communication. Nothing is hard. If nothing is hard, nothing is at stake. Distance means nothing if you can teleport. Injury means nothing if healing is instant. Separation means nothing if you can talk any time. The constraint engine stalls and the romance has to generate all its tension from pure interpersonal conflict, which gets exhausting fast.

FIX

Every convenient technology needs a cost, a limit, or a gap. Teleportation works but is agonisingly painful. Healing magic can mend bones but can't cure illness. The communication spell requires rare ingredients that are running out. *Fourth Wing* does this well: wyverns give riders extraordinary power, but the bonding process kills most candidates, signets come with physical costs, and Violet's body is genuinely fragile in ways that magic can't fully fix. The convenience exists, but it's never free. Give your reader a reason to worry.

Mistake #2: The Museum Piece

Technology is described in detail (the canal system, the printing press, the enchanted forges) but never actually affects the characters or the romance. It's worldbuilding decoration. Readers don't care about your canal system unless it determines whether two characters can reach each other. Technology that doesn't create or remove obstacles is just furniture.

FIX

For every technology you describe, ask yourself: "How does this affect my characters' ability to be together, communicate, or stay safe?" If the answer is "it doesn't," cut it or rethink it.

Mistake #3: The Inconsistency Problem

Technology rules shift to serve the plot. Messages arrive in hours when the plot needs urgency, but take weeks when the plot needs separation. Healing magic works perfectly in chapter three but mysteriously fails in chapter twelve. Readers track these rules even when they don't realise it. Inconsistency breaks trust and makes the romantic obstacles feel manufactured rather than organic.

What does your world's convenience cost? *The Convenience Trap stalls your romance when everything is easy. For every powerful or convenient technology in your world, identify what limits it, what it costs, or where it fails. If you can't find a cost, your constraint engine may be stalling.* | Convenient

Technology | What It Makes Easy | The Cost, Limit, or Gap | How the Cost Affects Your Romance | —|

-|-|-| Wyvern bond gives riders extraordinary power (Fourth Wing) | Travel, communication, combat

| Bonding kills most candidates; signets have physical costs; Violet's body is genuinely fragile | Power

comes with real danger — every flight could kill her, which keeps the stakes alive | | | | | | | | | |

| Technology Self-Check *Run through each technology you've described in this section. If you can't answer the first question, rethink whether you need it. If you struggle with the second, write down your*

rules now before inconsistency creeps in. | Technology | Does it affect your characters' ability to be together, communicate, or stay safe? (If no — cut or rethink) | What are its rules? (Write them down

so they stay consistent) | | - | - | - | | | | | | | | | |

FIX

Establish your rules early. Write them down for yourself. Constraint-driven tension is strongest when the constraint has an in-world logic (dragon biology, ward physics, reputation systems, institutional rules) and when it forces decisions that reveal character under pressure. When you need the plot to go differently, change the circumstances, not the rules. The message doesn't arrive faster; the character finds a faster method and pays for it. The healing doesn't fail; the injury is of a type that healing can't fix.

Overall Technology Level

Before diving into specifics, establish the broad strokes. Your approximate technology level sets the baseline for everything that follows, and knowing where it's uneven is where the interesting story possibilities live. When your characters come from regions with different technology levels, that gap becomes a source of wonder, discomfort, and misunderstanding that fuels romantic tension.

What's the approximate technology level?

Reference points: Stone Age, Bronze/Iron Age, Medieval, Renaissance, Early Modern, Industrial, Modern, Futuristic, Mixed/Uneven

Is technology consistent across your world, or does it vary?

Technological disparity creates power imbalances and dramatic opportunities when characters cross from one level to another. A character moving from a village with no running water to a city with enchanted plumbing experiences culture shock that reveals character and creates vulnerability.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Advanced regions	
Less advanced regions	
Why the disparity	

How does magic affect technology?

The relationship between magic and technology shapes what solutions are available, and to whom — and crucially, which character has access to magical solutions and which is left relying on slower, harder, non-magical alternatives.

RELATIONSHIP	DOES THIS APPLY IN YOUR WORLD?	DETAILS
Magic replaces technology		
Magic and technology coexist		
Magic stunts technological development		
Magic enhances technology		

Movement & Distance

Travel is the original romantic constraint. How much space there is between your characters and how difficult it is to get closer to each other will determine if the time apart is merely inconvenient or agonizing. Days together on the road create a completely different kind of intimacy than stepping through a portal. Sometimes the journey itself *is* the romance.

Forced proximity works by generating iterated contact under stakes: danger, surveillance, institutional rules. All of these increase the frequency of small intimacy opportunities. Shared routines, mutual

observation, training, tactical decisions. In *Fourth Wing*, Rebecca Yarros made this mechanism very clear through design: because Violet’s and Xaden’s dragons can’t be separated for more than a few days, Xaden has to go along with her travel and postings. The proximity is dictated by the biological nature of the dragons, not character choice, which means the characters can attribute their closeness to necessity rather than desire. However, even though the characters may maintain a facade of not wanting to be close, the relationship continues to grow beneath the surface.

But forced proximity doesn’t always require a road. In *The Cruel Prince*, Holly Black took the mechanism of forced proximity and placed it within the confines of the court. Oaths, glamour, and political surveillance replace travel as the thing that keeps characters in each other’s orbit. Jude can’t leave Faerie, can’t escape the court’s watchful eye, can’t move without being observed. The confinement is not physical but jurisdictional, and yet the results are the same: repeated contact with the pressure of being trapped, with no way out. Think about what forces *your* characters into proximity. Is it distance? Duty? Political obligation? An unbreakable bond? The specific mechanism that brings your characters close to each other is less important than the fact that they can’t walk away.

What transportation methods exist?

METHOD	SPEED	COST	WHO HAS ACCESS
On foot			
Riding animals	40–50 miles/day at easy pace	A good horse costs a year’s wages for a labourer	Nobility, wealthy merchants, military; commoners walk
Vehicles (carts, carriages)			

METHOD	SPEED	COST	WHO HAS ACCESS
Ships/boats			
Flying (creatures, vehicles)			
Magical transport	Instantaneous between paired mirrors	Priceless, only three working mirror-gates exist	Royal family only; using one without permission is treason

What's the fastest way to travel long distances?

The fastest method is often the most expensive or dangerous. What would your protagonist sacrifice for speed?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Method	
Limitations (cost, rarity, danger, who can use it)	

How long does travel take between important locations?

Travel time shapes the emotional weight of journeys, but don't overlook short-distance containment: a carriage ride across town can be just as powerful as a week-long journey. In *Bridgerton* Season 3, a

single carriage scene becomes the friends-to-lovers turning point. The enclosed space, the rhythmic movement, the inability to walk away mid-conversation. The carriage functions as a sealed room on wheels. What transport in your world creates that kind of pressurised intimacy?

ROUTE	TIME REQUIRED
Between major cities	
Across your world's span	
The journey your characters take	

What makes travel difficult or dangerous?

Danger on the road is one of romantasy's most reliable engines for intimacy. When characters face threats together, protection becomes care, and shared survival builds trust faster than any conversation.

DANGER	DETAILS
Weather and terrain	

DANGER	DETAILS
Bandits, creatures, hostile forces	
Cost and physical demands	
Other risks	

What travel infrastructure exists?

Roads, inns, and rest stops determine whether journeys are manageable or desperate. Where does infrastructure fail, and where might your characters find themselves alone, off the map, beyond observation?

INFRASTRUCTURE	DETAILS
Roads (quality, where they go)	
Bridges	

INFRASTRUCTURE	DETAILS
Ports and harbours	
Way stations, inns, caravanserais	
Stables and animal care	

Who maintains infrastructure?

When infrastructure breaks down, isolation follows — and isolation is where romantasy thrives. Knowing who maintains the roads and bridges tells you where they'll fail, and where your characters might find themselves stranded together.

Government? Local lords? Guilds? No one?

What happens where infrastructure doesn't exist?

Beyond the roads lies wilderness, danger, and freedom from observation. When might your characters venture there, and what does it mean for them to be beyond the reach of civilisation together?

YOUR ANSWER

Communication & Connection

Communication technology influences the pace at which people interact in relationships. When letters take weeks, you want to convey the ache of waiting. Reading letters over and over again until the ink begins to fade from the paper, the uncertainty of not knowing is agonising. When a message finally does arrive, slow down: recognise the handwriting, decide if you'll open it right away or wait until you can have some private time. Slow communication causes both dramatic irony (the reader knows something the character does not) and miscommunication that has had ample opportunity to develop into issues. Rapid magical communication produces a different type of tension: the urgency to respond as quickly as possible, the inability to utilise distance to conceal one's feelings, the intimate nature of immediate connection.

But communication constraints aren't just about speed. They also define what can and can't be said. Letters, as shown in *The Duke and I*, serve as a form of delayed emotional infrastructure. The pregnancy letter that Daphne writes to Simon must be delivered to him by her brother, and it's this slow process of delivering the letter that triggers Simon's eventual return. Lady Whistledown's gossip sheet serves as a public channel that limits what can be discussed privately. In *From Blood and Ash*, the communication restrictions are institutionalised: the Maiden's rules prohibit touch, direct speech, and even gazing upon another person. Any communication Poppy shares with Hawke is therefore a transgressive act against the rules that govern her life, and thus any exchange of basic words, such as a name, carries a great deal of weight.

Regardless of the technology, show your characters adjusting their behaviour to meet the constraints imposed by it. The use of codes in letters that may be intercepted, the frustration of having to wait for urgent news to travel, the elation of being able to speak openly for the first time.

What communication methods exist over distance?

Can your characters reach each other across distance, and at what cost?

METHOD	SPEED	RELIABILITY	PRIVACY
Hand-delivered letters			

METHOD	SPEED	RELIABILITY	PRIVACY
Courier/postal system	3–7 days between major cities	Reasonably reliable; royal post is faster but expensive	Low, anyone can read it en route; use codes for secrets
Messenger birds			
Signal systems (fire, flags)			
Magical communication	Instant for bonded pairs	Perfect between bonded items; requires rare enchantment	High, only the bonded holder can activate it

How long does it take to send a message between important locations?

Delayed messages create dramatic irony and miscommunication. What might change before a letter arrives?

ROUTE	TIME
Between major cities	

ROUTE	TIME
Between your characters when separated	

How reliable is communication?

Unreliable communication breeds misunderstanding, dramatic irony, and the ache of not knowing. A message that might never arrive carries a completely different emotional weight than one that's guaranteed.

Can messages be lost? Delayed? Intercepted? Altered?

What's the most secure way to communicate?

Secrets require secure channels. What lengths would your protagonist go to for truly private communication, and what would it cost them?

What's the fastest way to communicate?

Urgent messages carry weight — the decision to use the fastest method signals that something matters enough to pay the price. What would justify it?

How do your characters adapt to communication constraints?

Characters who live under communication constraints develop workarounds: codes, intermediaries, stolen moments of open speech. These adaptations become part of the romance's texture. A character who has never been able to speak openly will react powerfully when they finally can.

CONSTRAINT	HOW THEY ADAPT	WHAT IT COSTS THEM EMOTIONALLY
<i>The Maiden's communication ban (From Blood and Ash)</i>	<i>Every conversation with Hawke becomes a transgressive act</i>	<i>Even speaking her own name carries enormous weight</i>

Privacy & Observation

Privacy scarcity allows the most minor actions to have major significance, which means that as long as characters can't talk, touch, or linger around one another, every single action becomes a gesture. Show us characters that are extremely attentive to those who may overhear, watch, or come upon them at any second. Constantly waiting to hear the sound of someone walking up to their door. Whispering things that will still be heard. That sense of relief from having finally, *finally*, been able to achieve some level of privacy, but then the uncertainty as to what to do with the longed-for privacy.

Because of the court environment in *The Cruel Prince*, and the many layers of hierarchy and punishment associated with vulnerability, there are very few places in which true desires can be expressed authentically, except in secret or at the edge of secrecy. When Jude and Cardan finally kiss, Jude is taken aback by her reaction and immediately goes back into negotiating terms. Desire, even when private, has to be contained quickly, since exposure is too great a risk. In ACOTAR Under the Mountain, the concept of privacy doesn't exist literally: Rhysand has Feyre painted and clothed to allow him to recognise if anyone has touched her, making her entire body a space to be monitored. When Tamlin is able to touch her fingers and signal her to follow him to a private area, Rhysand is forced to use magic to remove all evidence (Tamlin's clothing is smeared with paint), in order to maintain plausible denial. This is what a character experiencing privacy scarcity looks like on paper: moments stolen, and quickly covered up, where even a single fingerprint may be lethal.

Illustrate how your characters create privacy when it's not available to them. A coded look. The conversation had in plain sight, but one that implies something much different than the actual words. A quick moment in a crowd, or behind a column. And when privacy is suddenly accessible, that shift should mean something. The door that closes, the vacant room, the space where they can finally speak freely without fear of reprisal. Privacy is more than the absence of witnesses; it's the mental shift that occurs when characters no longer have to perform.

In many historical and fantasy settings, the biggest privacy issue isn't surveillance technology. It's people. Servants, attendants, family members, and household staff see and hear everything. Their presence shapes what can be said and done, and who knows the household's secrets.

How private are domestic spaces?

The thickness of walls and the layout of rooms determine whether whispered words stay between two people or become public knowledge. Privacy at home — or the lack of it — shapes every intimate moment.

Wall thickness, separate rooms, who shares space:

Do locks exist? Who has them?

The ability to lock a door is the ability to create private space. A locked door means choosing vulnerability; an unlocked one means performing for an audience that could arrive at any moment.

Who in your world has that power, and who doesn't?

Who has access to private spaces?

A private space is only as private as the people who can enter it. If servants have keys, if family can walk in, if landlords can inspect, then "alone" is always conditional.

Servants, family members, landlords, officials:

What surveillance exists?

Surveillance determines how carefully your characters must perform in public. Magical scrying, spy networks, and informants all create different levels of pressure — and different risks if your characters are caught together.

Magical scrying? Spy networks? Informants? Nothing systematic?

Where can people have truly private conversations?

In a world where privacy is scarce, the locations where characters can speak freely become sacred. These are the places where masks drop, truths emerge, and the relationship can advance beyond what public performance allows.

What are the consequences of being overheard?

The stakes of privacy shape how carefully characters speak and act. If the wrong person hearing the wrong thing means execution, exile, or scandal, then every whispered word carries enormous weight — and every private moment becomes an act of courage.

Design a stolen moment for your characters.

In worlds where privacy is scarce, every stolen moment carries the weight of an entire scene. Think about how your characters would navigate surveillance to create a private interaction — and what the consequences would be if they were caught.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Where does the moment happen?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who or what are they hiding from?	
What do they do or say?	
How do they cover their tracks?	
What would happen if they were caught?	

Servants & Attendants

Do servants exist in your world? How common are they?

Servants witness everything. Their presence shapes what can be said and done, and who knows the household's secrets.

What do servants do, and what do they see?

Servants who dress, bathe, clean, and attend their employers witness the most private moments of their lives. A servant who handles personal items, sleeps nearby, or is present during vulnerable moments is a witness to everything your characters want to hide.

Cooking, cleaning, dressing, attending, managing households. Are they present for private moments? Do they handle personal items? Do they sleep nearby?

What's the relationship between servants and employers?

The nature of the servant-employer bond determines whether servants are allies or threats to your romance. A loyal retainer who becomes a confidant is a very different story element from an ambitious servant who trades secrets for advancement.

Loyal retainers? Interchangeable staff? Family-like? Strictly hierarchical?

Can servants be trusted with secrets?

What motivates a servant's loyalty — or disloyalty — affects whether your characters can ever truly be alone. A servant who becomes a trusted confidant can enable the romance; one who becomes an informant can destroy it.

What motivates their loyalty or disloyalty?

Do your characters have servants?

Think about how servants affect your characters' ability to have private moments, and whether any servants become confidants or threats.

CHARACTER	SERVANTS?	HOW THIS AFFECTS PRIVACY
Protagonist		
Love interest		

How do servants affect what your characters can do privately?

The constant presence of others shapes intimacy. What strategies do your characters use to find moments alone — and what happens when those strategies fail?

Daily Life & the Texture of Time

The rhythm of day-to-day living will determine how much time people have for all the things that aren't work, including romance, education, and ambition. These details also shape the sensory world

of your story: the quality of light, the temperature of rooms, the smell of a city, what meals look and taste like. If you get these correct, it helps make the world of your story feel lived-in. Get them wrong (or ignore them) and readers will pick up on something missing, even if they can't say why.

Lighting shapes the emotional tone of every scene. Candlelight is soft, warm, and creates shadows and feelings of closeness. Faces half-lit, features rendered gentle. Torchlight is much harsher, flickering, creates drama and unease. Daylight reveals everything; characters can't hide in full sun. Dim lighting requires proximity to one another: leaning closer to see, speaking softer because darkness feels private. When characters are together in the dark, let the other senses become heightened. Sound, touch, the awareness of warmth from another body. The practical realities matter too. Candles burn out and go out, someone must tend the fire, darkness comes whether you're ready or not.

Time & Labour

How much time do ordinary people spend on survival tasks?

Time spent on survival is time unavailable for romance, education, or ambition. If your protagonist spends half the day hauling water, that shapes what kind of relationship is even possible.

TASK	TIME REQUIRED
Food preparation	
Water collection	
Heating/fuel	

TASK	TIME REQUIRED
Cleaning/maintenance	

Who does this labour?

Who does the work shapes who has time for anything else, including romance. If your protagonist spends hours on survival tasks while your love interest has servants handling everything, that gap in daily reality affects how they understand each other.

Servants? Women? Lower classes? Everyone? Magical solutions?

How much leisure time exists, and for whom?

Leisure is unequally distributed. If your characters come from different classes, their relationship to time differs — and that difference shapes what “spending time together” even means.

CLASS	LEISURE TIME
Wealthy	
Middle class	
Poor/working class	

What does the disparity in free time mean for your characters?

If one character has leisure and one doesn't, the imbalance shapes every interaction. The character who works all day experiences an evening visit very differently from the one who was free all afternoon. How does this gap affect their relationship?

Lighting & Darkness

How do people light their spaces?

Lighting technology shapes the emotional palette of every scene you write. Candlelight softens; torchlight unsettles; darkness heightens every other sense. What your characters see by determines what they feel.

Candles, oil lamps, torches, magical light, gas, electricity:

How expensive is lighting?

If staying up after dark is a luxury, then a character who can afford candlelight lives in a different world from one who goes to bed at sunset. An evening invitation that requires lighting becomes a marker of class — and a character who's never seen a well-lit room will react to one.

Can everyone afford to stay up after dark, or is darkness the norm for the poor?

What does nighttime look like?

Darkness creates different moods in different settings. Danger in unlighted streets, intimacy in candlelit rooms, isolation in rural darkness. Where your characters are when the sun goes down shapes what's possible between them.

LOCATION	LIGHTING AT NIGHT
In cities	
In homes	

LOCATION	LIGHTING AT NIGHT
In the countryside	

What can and can't be done after dark?

Darkness limits and enables. Some activities become impossible; others — secret meetings, escapes, confessions — become easier. What does nightfall make possible for your characters that daylight forbids?

How does lighting shape a key romantic scene?

Candlelight softens features and creates intimacy. Torchlight flickers and unsettles. Darkness heightens every other sense — sound, touch, the awareness of warmth from another body. Think about a scene where lighting shapes the emotional tone of an interaction between your characters.

ASPECT	DETAILS
The scene	
What lighting exists	
How the lighting affects mood and what characters can see	

Heating, Cooling & Shelter

How do people stay warm?

Extreme cold is one of romantasy's most reliable forced-proximity engines. Shared body heat turns survival into intimacy, and the snowbound inn works precisely because the shared bed is a survival decision rather than a romantic one — at first.

Fireplaces, central heating, braziers, body heat, magical warmth:

How do people stay cool?

Heat creates its own brand of vulnerability — lighter clothing, bare skin, seeking shade or water together. How your characters manage heat shapes the sensory texture of warm-weather scenes.

Fans, shade, water, magical cooling, architectural solutions:

What's the danger from extreme temperatures?

Can cold or heat kill? What do people do to survive extremes? Extreme cold is a classic forced-proximity engine, because sharing warmth becomes necessity, then intimacy. The snowbound inn in *ACOMAF* works precisely because the cold outside makes the shared bed inside a survival decision rather than a romantic one (at first). What temperature extremes exist in your world, and how might they push your characters together?

Water, Sanitation & Bathing

How and when people bathe is much more important than it would seem. Romantasy has no shortage of bathing scenes for their own brand of intimacy, and how those bathing scenes work are almost completely dependent on what sort of technology level you've established for your world. There's vulnerability in water; there's exposure in undressing; there's atmosphere in the place (river, bathhouse, private chamber with a copper tub). But the type of tension created by bathing in a public bathhouse is very different from the type of tension created by bathing in a private tub. A river provides a very different type of exposure from a screened-off tub in a room being shared with someone else.

Historically speaking, people didn't bathe as frequently as they do today. They would wash their linens, use dry-heat baths and perfume themselves. If your world is pre-industrial then a true bath can be considered a luxury item that signifies wealth, caring for oneself, or a significant event, which means the act of bathing, or being bathed, can have even greater significance.

Water scenes can serve two distinctly different romantic purposes in romantasy. The first is **safety and domestication**: in order for a couple to experience a bath together it must mean they're willing to share a domestic future and spend time together in a private space. This is evident in the bath scene in *Bridgerton* between Benedict and Sophie, signifying a shared future where both can engage in private bodily care. Similarly, the bathtub scene in *ACOMAF* is a way to decompress after being in danger and represents intimacy earned through survival. The second function is **dangerous vulnerability**:

in *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy falls asleep in the tub and is discovered, with the bathing process staged as exposure to her loss of autonomy. In *The Cruel Prince*, water serves as a symbol of dangerous sovereignty (Undersea politics) instead of a place of relaxation. Determine which purpose of water you want to use. Will water provide a safe haven for your characters or will it represent a place of danger?

What role does water/bathing play in your romance?

Water scenes can serve two very different romantic purposes: safety and domestication (intimacy earned through shared vulnerability in a private space) or dangerous vulnerability (exposure, loss of autonomy, sovereignty). Knowing which function you want helps you design the scene's emotional architecture.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What bathing looks like for your protagonist	
What bathing looks like for your love interest	
Is there a bathing/water scene in your story?	
Which function does it serve: safety or danger?	
What makes this moment emotionally significant?	

How do people get clean water?

Wells, rivers, aqueducts, pumps, magical purification:

YOUR ANSWER

How do people bathe?

Public bathhouses, private baths, rivers/lakes, basins, rarely:

YOUR ANSWER

FREQUENCY

What sanitation exists?

Sanitation shapes the sensory world your characters inhabit. A city with open sewers smells and feels very different from one with magical waste disposal — and these details make your world feel lived-in.

Sewers, chamber pots, outhouses, magical waste disposal:

What are the health implications of sanitation level?

Disease, cleanliness, and smell all flow from sanitation. A world where illness is common is a world where vulnerability is constant — and where staying healthy is never guaranteed.

Disease, cleanliness, smell:

YOUR ANSWER

What does your world smell like, and how do your characters smell?

A world without the sanitation we have today will be smelly. Cities smell. People smell. Woodsmoke, horse, leather, herbs, sweat. These are the sensory details that make a world feel real. The love interest's distinctive scent is a genre staple: Yennefer's letters smell of lilac and gooseberries in *The Witcher*. Bardugo's Darkling fills a room with the scent of winter wind and bare branches in *Siege and Storm*. In *Duke of Sin*, Elizabeth Hoyt has her hero find the heroine's unwashed scent (sweat, sex, earth) deeply enticing rather than repellent.

The key to using this technique is selective realism. Identify the general odour of your world (peat smoke, river mud, tallow candles), then describe your love interest's unique scent against that background. Give the pleasant scent an in-world justification: herbal wash, scented oils, magical essence, or simply the poetic focus of a narrator who's falling in love and notices only the good. Show how scent makes the character *feel* (calmed, electrified, achingly nostalgic) rather than cataloguing what they literally smell. And real humans are drawn to partners whose scent signals genetic compatibility, so a heroine overwhelmed by her love interest's scent isn't just genre convention. There's biology underneath it.

What does your world smell like, and what does your love interest smell like against that background?

Scent is one of romantasy's most powerful sensory tools. Identify the baseline smells of your world, then layer your love interest's distinctive scent on top. The contrast between the ordinary and the intoxicating is what makes it land on the page.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What does your world generally smell like? (Woodsmoke, horse, river mud, tallow, herbs)	
What does your love interest smell like?	
What's the in-world justification for their scent? (Herbal wash, oils, magic, or just the narrator falling in love)	
How does their scent make your protagonist <i>feel</i> ?	

Food & Drink

Food is one of the fastest ways to demonstrate differences in social status on the page. A meal that two characters from completely different worlds share will tell you everything you need to know: the character who has never eaten anything sweet, the one who doesn't recognise peasant bread, the moment when giving food is considered a gesture of care. To prepare a meal for another person is to create a sense of closeness. To watch another person enjoy a new type of food is to gain a greater understanding of them.

Meals also serve as soft diplomacy where characters may engage in building trust through commonality in an everyday experience. In ACOTAR, the first dinners Feyre shares with Tamlin place a poor human huntress within the High Fae aristocracy. Through these experiences, she learns the rules of that world; incorrect perceptions are resolved; Tamlin shares his politics as if signing a formal treaty. The physical space of the table is transformed through the use of magic to draw the two characters closer together, domestic magic as a flirting mechanism rather than relying upon architectural features. In *From Blood and Ash*, sharing a meal with a captor-protector is a way to signal that you'll support or defend each other politically. Daphne in *Bridgerton* shares tea with the housekeeper to learn about her husband's childhood, which is an example of crossing social classes to develop a relationship, and the housekeeper holds the knowledge that Daphne was previously denied. Each time characters share a meal they're negotiating power. Who will host? Who will serve? Who will speak? Who may depart?

How is food preserved?

Preservation methods shape what's available and when. A world that relies on seasonal eating creates different meal-sharing dynamics than one with year-round variety — and a character who's only ever eaten preserved food will react very differently to fresh fruit.

Salting, smoking, drying, pickling, cold storage, magical preservation:

How does food preservation affect daily life?

Whether food is fresh or preserved affects what meals look like, what seasons feel like, and what counts as a luxury. A fresh peach in winter is a very different gift than one in summer.

Fresh food daily? Seasonal eating? Long-term storage possible?

What food is available to different classes?

Food marks class in visible ways. A shared meal across class lines reveals everything: the character who's never eaten anything sweet reacts differently to a feast than the one who takes it for granted.

CLASS	FOOD AVAILABLE
Wealthy	

CLASS	FOOD AVAILABLE
Common	
Poor	

How does food reveal the dynamic between your characters?

Shared meals are power negotiations. Who hosts, who serves, who speaks, who may leave — all of this communicates status, care, and vulnerability. A character who has never eaten anything sweet reacts differently to a feast than the character who takes it for granted.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What does your protagonist typically eat?	
What does your love interest typically eat?	
Is there a food gap between them?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
What would a shared meal between them reveal?	
Could a meal become a turning point in their relationship? How?	

Timekeeping

How do people tell time, and how precise is it?

Sun position, bells, clocks, magical timekeepers. Imprecise timekeeping matters for romance: “meet me at sunset” creates ambiguity that “meet me at 6:15 PM” doesn’t. If time is vague, characters wait. They wonder if they’ve been stood up. They arrive early out of eagerness or late out of pride. The precision of your world’s clocks shapes the emotional texture of every planned meeting.

Do people schedule precisely, or approximately?

DO PEOPLE SCHEDULE PRECISELY, OR APPROXIMATELY?

Bodies & Vulnerability

Technology and the body intersect in medicine and reproduction; the body is also where romance lives. How will the injuries and health challenges facing your characters affect them? How will those issues be treated? What will be the emotional ramifications of physical intimacy? These determine some of the most emotionally charged moments in your story. A world where all wounds can be healed removes all of the risk from injury and makes your characters invincible. A world where a fever could result in death is a world of vulnerability and will break open your characters.

Caretaking is such a powerful element of romantasy, for it turns romantic feelings into actions. When a character shows up to stay with another injured character, or hold them, or tend to their injuries, or teach them how to ground themselves, this proves their love in ways that talking cannot. In *Fourth Wing*, Violet finds herself in a hospital bed after being wounded during a battle, and Xaden is there beside her. This is a classic hurt/comfort beat where the act of caring is evidence of attachment. In *From Blood and Ash*, Hawke physically calms Poppy down after she becomes overwhelmed by the emotional response of a crowd, and this act of caring reads as co-regulation in a society where she's unable to openly express herself due to the dangers posed by her abilities. Hawke later gives Poppy part of his own blood to save her life after she's been stabbed, and in doing so he not only heals her but also reveals much about himself and transforms the entire nature of the relationship.

Sophie cares for Benedict in *Bridgerton* while he's suffering from a fever at an isolated cottage, which is the Regency era equivalent of "the only healer within a reasonable distance." Fever is inherently a sensory experience: heat, wet hair, and delirious speech. And fever has a unique ability to cause people to confess things they'd never normally admit to, even though they may say things in a state of delirium that they'd never say while sober. The limited medical capabilities of the time (rest, warmth, broth, constant observation) create an intimate environment because the only places where this can occur are away from the prying eyes of chaperones and social expectations of propriety. Isolated locations like cottages and inns represent a form of low-technology containment.

When writing these types of scenes, keep in mind that medical environments tend to become confession environments. When people are sick or injured, they rely on others for care and support, and this dependence often creates a need for compromise or a need to reveal information that changes everything.

Medicine & Healing

What medical knowledge exists?

Medical technology determines what injuries are survivable and what illnesses are death sentences. The gap between “hurt” and “dying” is where caretaking intimacy lives — and your world’s medicine determines how wide that gap is.

CONDITION	TREATMENT AVAILABLE	EFFECTIVENESS
Wounds/injuries		
Infection		
Common illness		
Serious disease		
Childbirth		
Pain		

Who provides medical care?

The person who heals is in a position of extraordinary intimacy: they see the body vulnerable, they touch without the usual social barriers, they hold knowledge about what hurts. Who provides that care in your world shapes who holds that power.

Physicians, healers, midwives, herbalists, magical healers, family members:

What determines access to medical care?

Unequal access to healing is one of the most emotionally charged technology gaps in romantasy. If one character can afford a magical healer and the other can't, that disparity becomes visible every time someone gets hurt.

Cost? Location? Class? Connections?

Does magical healing exist?

Magical healing can remove stakes from injuries — unless it has limits, costs, or is inaccessible to your characters. The most effective romantasy healing systems give with one hand and take with the other.

ASPECT	DETAILS
How common	
How effective	
What it can't heal	
Cost/limitations	

What injuries or illnesses are survivable vs. fatal?

Understanding what can and can't be healed helps you write realistic stakes. If everything is survivable, danger loses its weight. If too much is fatal, you lose the caretaking scenes where romance deepens.

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES
Easily treated	
Survivable with care	
Usually fatal	

What chronic conditions exist, and how are they managed?

Chronic illness shapes daily life in ways acute injury doesn't. A character who lives with ongoing health concerns experiences vulnerability differently — it's not a single dramatic moment but a constant reality that the love interest must understand and accommodate.

Contraception & Reproduction

What contraception exists?

In romantasy, contraception technology — or its absence — directly affects intimate scenes and their consequences. What options your characters have shapes what intimacy means and what risks it carries.

METHOD	EFFECTIVENESS	AVAILABILITY
Herbal/natural		
Barrier methods		
Magical prevention		

Who has access to contraception?

Access to contraception is rarely equal. Class, gender, knowledge, and cost all shape who can control the consequences of intimacy — and who can't.

Available to all? Expensive? Forbidden? Requires specific knowledge? Class-dependent?

What happens if contraception fails or isn't used?

The consequences of unprotected intimacy shape how characters approach physical closeness. Social, legal, and practical consequences all affect the weight of every intimate scene.

Social consequences? Legal consequences? Practical consequences?

Is there pressure on anyone to produce heirs?

Heir pressure is one of romantasy's most powerful engines. It can force marriages, forbid them, or make certain relationships politically explosive. Who faces this pressure changes everything about what love is allowed to look like.

Who faces this pressure and from whom?

Do fertility issues exist?

Infertility or difficulty conceiving adds another layer of vulnerability and stakes to intimate relationships, particularly where heir pressure exists.

Infertility, difficulty conceiving, magical interference:

YOUR ANSWER

Identity & Documentation

Official documents allow for certain possibilities and restrict others. Where documentation is rigidly enforced, there are definitive identities, marriages can be proven, and your history will follow you. Without official documentation, you can reinvent yourself, unions can remain private and no one can verify your true identity. Each option provides potential for romantic engagement, just in vastly different ways.

Gaps in documentation and literacy create some of romantasy's most intense moments. When Feyre is *Under the Mountain* in *ACOTAR*, she's put into a situation where she must solve a puzzle with writing on the levers. Feyre can't read the writing and the danger is created by the "tech gap" she has. Rhysand finds out that Feyre is illiterate and decides to keep it a secret, creating both leverage and protection. Readers and critics have extensively discussed how Feyre's lack of reading skills were treated, since readers consider tech gaps as moral indicators of a love interest's behaviour: does he educate, shame, hide, or use her lack of education for his own gain?

Whether a character conceals their identity or reveals it is entirely dependent upon the level of technological advancement of their world. In *The Cruel Prince*, a character uses glamour and vows to sustain their identity. Magical social norms make revealing a character's identity physical (a kiss, a whisper, a demand) rather than documentary. For *From Blood and Ash*, Hawke maintains his alias through role-based access; while serving as a guard, Hawke can be physically close to Poppy without raising her suspicions, which creates a security system vulnerability that's used for romance. Lady Whistledown's anonymous identity in *Bridgerton* is protected by print technology (ink, printers, delivery systems), so a character must reveal their identity through direct confrontation to move the secret from being printed to spoken word. Ask yourself: in your world what maintains the secrecy of a character's identity and what do you need to break it wide open?

What documentation exists?

DOCUMENT TYPE	WHO KEEPS RECORDS	HOW RELIABLE
Birth records		

DOCUMENT TYPE	WHO KEEPS RECORDS	HOW RELIABLE
Death records		
Marriage records		
Identity documents		
Property records		

How do people prove identity?

How identity is verified determines whether your characters can hide who they are — and what it takes to expose them. A world that relies on personal knowledge is very different from one with magical verification.

Personal knowledge? Documents? Witnesses? Magical verification?

What makes a marriage legally valid and provable?

Marriage documentation affects inheritance, legitimacy, and whether unions can be hidden or denied. What your characters need for a legal marriage — and what happens without it — shapes whether secret unions are possible.

What happens without documentation?

If there's no proof of birth, identity, or marriage, the consequences can be liberating or devastating. A character with no records can reinvent themselves; a character who can't prove their marriage has no legal protection.

If there's no proof of birth, identity, or marriage, what are the consequences?

Can documents be falsified?

Forged documents open possibilities: new identities, secret marriages made official, inconvenient births erased. But the risk of discovery adds its own tension.

How difficult is it? What would it require? What are the risks?

Material Culture

What characters wear, where they live, and how they spend leisure time creates the sensory texture of your world, and all of it communicates class, status, and belonging. These details are often where characters from different backgrounds first notice the gulf between them.

Clothing & Textiles

What materials are clothes made from?

Fabric speaks to wealth, region, and practicality. What your protagonist's clothing communicates before they say a word — and how starkly it contrasts with what the love interest wears — tells the reader everything about the gap between their worlds.

How are clothes made?

How clothes are produced affects how easily your characters can disguise themselves, blend into another class, or replace clothing damaged in action.

Hand-sewn, tailored, mass-produced:

How complicated is getting dressed?

Can people dress themselves, or do they need help? Clothing that requires assistance is a privacy issue, and undressing becomes an act that requires trust.

What does clothing signal about class and status?

Clothing can be a disguise, a mark of belonging, or an insurmountable barrier. When your characters cross class lines, what they're wearing is the first thing that betrays or protects them — and the first thing a love interest notices.

Construction & Architecture

Architecture shapes where intimacy is possible. Thick stone walls muffle sound; timber partitions don't. A tower room isolates; an open longhouse exposes. Whether your characters live in a sprawling palace or a single-room dwelling determines what privacy looks like and what "alone together" actually means.

What are buildings made from, and what does that mean for privacy?

Stone castles, timber halls, mud-brick dwellings. Each creates different atmospheres and different levels of sound isolation. Can your characters be heard through the walls?

How tall can buildings be?

Height limits shape cityscapes and the symbolic power of towers. What does it mean when someone

What architectural features are common?

WHAT ARCHITECTURAL FEATURES ARE COMMON?

Entertainment & Leisure

Entertainment creates the settings where characters interact outside of duty, danger, or obligation. Dances, performances, feasts, and games are where romantic tension plays out in public. Characters can touch under the guise of a dance, watch each other across a crowded room, or compete in ways that become charged with something more than sport.

What entertainment exists?

Entertainment creates the settings where characters interact outside of duty, danger, or obligation. Dances allow sanctioned touch, performances allow shared emotional experience, and competitions channel desire into something publicly acceptable. Which of these create opportunities for your characters to interact in ways their normal lives wouldn't allow?

What technology enables entertainment?

The instruments, spaces, and equipment that make entertainment possible also shape where characters gather and what they do together. A ballroom requires musicians; a tournament requires a field. What does your world's entertainment infrastructure look like?

Musical instruments, game equipment, performance spaces:

What technologies are luxuries only the wealthy can afford?

Luxury technologies mark class distinction. What would immediately identify someone as wealthy — or as someone pretending to be? When your characters cross class lines, these are the details that betray or protect them.

What technologies are available to everyone, and what is completely out of reach for the poor?

Inaccessible technology creates invisible barriers. What would a poor character simply never encounter in their normal life — and how would they react when they first experienced it alongside a love interest who takes it for granted?

Weapons & Conflict

In romantasy, weapons are used as much for creating a scene around the fight as they are to create the actual battle. Combat doesn't always have to be about the action; it can also be about the moments that occur before or after the actual fighting takes place. Training sequences where one character teaches another how to fight. Sparring matches that become charged with tension. The simple gesture of handing a weapon to another person, which is a gesture of trust. That feeling of being vulnerable and disarmed, when everyone else has the ability to arm themselves. In addition to creating a sense of who has the upper hand physically, this theme bleeds into all interactions of characters in a novel.

Both romantic scenes and combat scenes follow the same basic structure: they begin to build tension, lead up to some sort of physical contact, and ultimately require the characters involved to be vulnerable. In *Fourth Wing*, Violet is attracted to Xaden because he's shirtless while sparring. The two eventually train together with daggers, creating a sense of intimacy as each parry and counter builds on the trust already established. For *A Court of Mist and Fury*, Cassian trains Feyre in hand-to-hand combat. She hits Cassian's sparring pads so hard and for so long that her rage literally burns away from her body, and the training session serves as both a form of catharsis and a way for Feyre to prove herself as a worthy partner. The court tournament in *The Cruel Prince* takes the same concept, but turns the dynamic of violence and desire darker. Cardan's physical domination of Jude in combat is charged with humiliation and sexual tension and the author does this intentionally to blur the lines of violence and desire.

The biggest difference between the two is that *sparring* is a consensual and eroticised form of intimacy that occurs within the safety of the practice session. But *actual combat* is non-consensual and dangerous. You can use either as a means to develop a romantic relationship, but you'll use them very differently.

What weapons exist?

Available weapons shape both conflict and protection. What your protagonist can fight with — or against — determines the physical stakes of every dangerous scene and how much they depend on the person beside them.

TYPE	EXAMPLES
Melee weapons	
Ranged weapons	
Siege weapons	
Magical weapons	

What armour exists?

Armour protects but also constrains. A character in full plate is safe but untouchable; a character in leather is vulnerable but mobile. The trade-off between protection and accessibility is a physical metaphor for the emotional walls your characters build.

What's the most advanced military technology?

The cutting edge of warfare reveals what powers fear most. What weapons or defences give decisive advantage — and how does that shape the danger your characters face?

Who has access to weapons?

A character who's forbidden from carrying weapons faces danger differently than one who is armed — and depends differently on the person beside them. Weapon restrictions also shape training dynamics: if your protagonist isn't allowed to train, learning in secret becomes an act of rebellion and trust.

Restricted to military/nobility? Commonly owned? Forbidden to certain groups?

Does weapons training exist, and who has access to it?

Training scenes are some of romantasy's most effective tension-builders. Physical proximity, physical contact, one person in a position of authority over another's body, all under the socially acceptable cover of "practice." Choreograph these scenes like intimate dances: combine blows with glances, describe the grip of a hand correcting stance, the stinging muscle, the heart pounding. Use setting to amplify tension. Cramped sparring halls force proximity, dim torchlight creates mood. And pay attention to the aftermath: the exhilaration, the embarrassment, the way characters can't quite look at each other once the weapons are put down. Who trains your characters, and could that dynamic become romantic?

Is there a training or sparring dynamic between your characters?

Training scenes work because they disguise intimacy as necessity: physical proximity, physical contact, one person in authority over another's body, all under the cover of "practice." If your characters train together or one teaches the other, map the romantic potential.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Who trains whom (or do they spar as equals)?	
What weapon or skill is being taught?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
What creates the tension (proximity, authority, vulnerability)?	
What happens in the aftermath — how do they act once weapons are put down?	

Does your story use sparring, actual combat, or both to develop the romance?

Sparring and combat serve different romantic functions. Sparring is consensual intimacy disguised as practice — it builds trust, creates sanctioned touch, and lets characters attribute their physical awareness to necessity. Actual combat is dangerous vulnerability under real threat — it bonds through shared survival and reveals who your characters are when stakes are lethal. Knowing which you’re using, and when, helps you control the tone.

Knowledge & Education

Who has access to information and who does not, shapes power dynamics in romance just as much as wealth or title. The ability to read when others can't is a particularly significant form of power. In a world where books are hard to come by, the value of giving one as a gift is based on the fact that books are scarce. And the act of teaching someone to read, sharing knowledge, or revealing a hidden library is an act of trust and intimacy that technology level makes possible.

What do people write on?

Writing surfaces affect who can communicate in writing and how portable that communication is. A love letter carved into wax is a very different object from one inked on paper — and the material itself signals what the writer had access to.

Paper, parchment, clay, wax tablets, magical surfaces:

What do people write with?

Writing tools affect who can communicate in writing and how portable that communication is. A quill and ink require a desk; a charcoal stick works anywhere. What your characters have access to shapes what they can say and where they can say it.

YOUR ANSWER

How are books made?

How books are produced determines how scarce they are — and scarcity changes their meaning. In a world where every book is hand-copied, giving one is an act of extraordinary generosity and intimacy.

Hand-copied, printed, magically reproduced:

How expensive and rare are books?

The scarcity of books affects who has access to knowledge, and how precious a single volume might be as a gift, an inheritance, or a sign of trust between two people who share what others can't access.

Who can access education?

Education access shapes the power dynamic between your characters more than almost any other technology. If one can read and the other can't, if one has been trained and the other hasn't, that gap becomes a source of dependency, shame, or intimacy. Teaching someone is an act of trust; being taught is an act of vulnerability.

Universal? Class-restricted? Gender-restricted? If your characters come from different education levels, how does that gap affect their dynamic? Does one teach the other, and what does that teaching look like?

Does knowledge create a power dynamic between your characters?

When one character can read and the other can't, when one has access to information the other is denied, the knowledge gap becomes a source of dependency, shame, or intimacy. Teaching someone is an act of trust. Withholding knowledge is an act of control.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Does either character have knowledge the other lacks?	
Does one teach the other anything? What?	
How does the knowledge gap affect their dynamic (dependency, shame, wonder, trust)?	

Magic & Technology Integration

If your world has magic, it doesn't exist in a vacuum. It interacts with technology, replaces it, enhances it, or conflicts with it. The key question for romance isn't "how does magic work?" but "who has access to magical solutions and who doesn't?" That asymmetry drives character dynamics.

Does magic replace certain technologies?

When magic fills a need that technology would otherwise serve, it changes who has access to solutions. If magical heating replaces fireplaces, then characters without magic are left in the cold — literally and figuratively.

What technology doesn't exist because magic fills the need:

Does magic enhance technology?

Enchanted items and magitech create a world where some tools are more powerful than they should be — and access to those enhanced tools becomes another axis of inequality between your characters.

Enchanted items, magitech:

Do magic and technology conflict?

If magic interferes with technology or vice versa, your characters may have to choose between magical and technological solutions — and that choice reveals what they value and who they trust.

Does magic interfere with technology or vice versa?

Who has access to magical vs. technological solutions?

Magic and technology may solve similar problems differently. Which solution is available to your protagonist, and which is beyond reach? The gap between magical and mundane solutions is often the gap between your characters' worlds.

How does the magic/technology divide affect your characters' relationship?

When one character has access to magical solutions and the other relies on slower, harder alternatives, the gap creates dependency, resentment, or wonder. This asymmetry is fuel for romantic tension.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What magical solution does one character have that the other doesn't?	

ASPECT	DETAILS
How does the character without magic solve the same problem?	
Does this create dependency, resentment, wonder, or something else?	

Lost or Forbidden Technology

Did past civilisations have technology now lost?

Lost technology creates mystery and possibility. What ancient wonders might your characters discover or seek — and could the quest to find them bring your characters together or drive them apart?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What was lost	
Why it was lost	
Could it be rediscovered	

Is any technology restricted or forbidden?

Forbidden technology creates temptation and danger. A character willing to risk punishment to access forbidden knowledge or tools reveals how much they're willing to sacrifice — and a shared secret about forbidden technology binds characters together.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What's restricted	
Who restricts it and why	
Consequences for using it	

Technology & Your Characters

Now that you've established your world's technology level, think about how it specifically affects your characters. This is where the worldbuilding becomes personal, where abstract rules about communication speed and medical access become the concrete reality of your romance. Some of these questions may echo earlier ones — that's intentional. Earlier, you were building the world's systems. Now you're asking: what do those systems mean for these two people specifically?

What technology does each character have access to?

Differing access creates imbalance. What does each character take for granted that the other finds remarkable or impossible?

CHARACTER	TECHNOLOGY ACCESS
Protagonist	
Love interest	

Is there a technology gap between them?

Technology gaps create friction, dependency, and curiosity — all the raw material romance is built from. A character who's never seen enchanted light arriving in a palace full of it experiences wonder that reveals vulnerability, while the character who takes it for granted sees their world through new eyes.

What does one have that the other doesn't?

How does this affect their dynamic?

Technology gaps can create dependency, wonder, shame, or teaching moments. The character who teaches reveals patience or condescension; the one who learns reveals pride or openness. How does the disparity shape how they see each other?

How do they communicate when separated?

Distance communication shapes the texture of separation. Letters reread until worn, messages that might never arrive, or instant magical contact. Each creates a different emotional reality.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Method	

ASPECT	DETAILS
How long messages take	
What risk exists in their communication	

What privacy do they have?

Privacy determines where intimacy is possible. Where and when can your characters be truly alone together — and what changes when they finally are?

ASPECT	DETAILS
Where can they be alone	
Who might observe or overhear them	

If one character has servants/attendants, how does that affect privacy?

Attendants are witnesses. What must your characters hide even from loyal servants, and what happens if servants aren't loyal?

Does either character face medical issues?

Illness and injury create vulnerability. Caring for someone sick is intimacy of a different kind — it proves love in ways that words cannot. What might that reveal between your characters?

ASPECT	DETAILS
What condition	
What treatment exists	
Does one care for the other during illness/ injury	

How does contraception (or lack thereof) affect them?

The availability and reliability of contraception shapes what intimacy means and what consequences your characters might face. This is where worldbuilding meets the most personal moments of your romance.

ASPECT	DETAILS
Is it available to them	
Is it something they discuss or navigate	

Could they marry secretly with no record?

Secret marriage is a classic romantasy option, but documentation requirements determine whether it can stay secret and what risks exist. A union no one can prove is also a union no one can disprove.

ASPECT	DETAILS
What would be required	
What risks would exist	

Integration Check

QUESTION	CONNECTION	EXAMPLE
How does geography affect technology? (Section 1)	Mountains, rivers, and climate shape what tech is possible and where it reaches	Mountain passes close in winter, cutting off communication for months
What technology drives the economy? (Section 4)	Key industries depend on specific technologies	Enchanted forges create the kingdom's wealth, and its military advantage
How does government use or restrict technology? (Section 5)	Governments control access to create power imbalances	Only licensed mages may operate mirror-gates; unlicensed use is treason

QUESTION	CONNECTION	EXAMPLE
How does technology affect different classes? (Section 5)	Technology access maps onto class structure	Nobles have magical heating; commoners burn peat and share beds for warmth
How does magic interact with technology? (Magic System)	Magic may replace, enhance, or conflict with technology	Healing magic makes surgery unnecessary, but only for those who can afford a healer

Quick Reference: Technology Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE
Overall tech level		Medieval with magical enhancements
Travel speed (between key locations)		Capital to border: 3 weeks by horse, instant by mirror-gate (royal only)
Communication speed		Letters: 5 days between cities; bonded items: instant but rare
Communication security		Letters can be intercepted; magical comms private but traceable
Privacy level		Low: thin walls, servants present, court surveillance

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE
Servant presence		Protagonist has none; love interest has three attendants always present
Medical capabilities		Healing magic exists but can't cure poison or illness
Contraception availability		Herbal methods known but unreliable; magical prevention expensive
Documentation requirements		Marriage requires witnesses and temple record; births unrecorded in rural areas
Technology gap between characters		She's never seen enchanted light; he's never cooked his own food

Final Thought: Make It Personal

You've built the systems. Now break them, for your characters specifically. The most memorable romantasy technology moments aren't about the world's rules in the abstract. They're about the moment your character realises they can't get a message sent in time. The moment your love interest discovers he can't lock the door. The moment a wound won't heal and someone has to stay.

Technology isn't about gadgets. It's about what your world makes easy and what it makes hard. The best constraint is the one your characters feel in their bones.